

**UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE
READY WRITING CONTEST**

HIGH SCHOOL TOPICS

STATE • 2025

Read both of the following statements carefully; then write an expository essay on a topic clearly related to one or the other of the two statements. **Provide your own title.** You are not expected to write on both topics.

Contestants who are hand-writing their compositions must use their own standard 8 1/2 x 11-inch ruled white notebook paper or typing paper, or the paper provided by the host school. Contestants shall write or print the composition **in ink and on only one side of the paper.** If contestants choose to use their own laptop computers, they must bring portable printers and associated hardware, software and paper. The typed entry must be single-sided and double-spaced, using any standard 12-point font on 8 1/2 x 11-inch white paper. When printing the contest on an electronic printer, the print command must be started by the time contest time expires. Students who opt to compose their entries on computers accept the risk of computer malfunction. In case of computer malfunction, the contestant may use the remaining allotted time to complete the composition in handwriting or compose on another computer (if available).

Ready Writing prompts are provided as springboards for thought, not to advocate particular points of view. Contestants should not conclude that quotations or statements used in prompts reflect the opinion of the UIL.

Topic I

“I have a foreboding of an America in my children's or grandchildren's time -- when the United States is a service and information economy; when nearly all the key manufacturing industries have slipped away to other countries; when awesome technological powers are in the hands of a very few, and no one representing the public interest can even grasp the issues; when the people have lost the ability to set their own agendas or knowledgeably question those in authority; when, clutching our crystals and nervously consulting our horoscopes, our critical faculties in decline, unable to distinguish between what feels good and what's true, we slide, almost without noticing, back into superstition and darkness.

The dumbing down of American is most evident in the slow decay of substantive content in the enormously influential media, the 30-second sound bites (now down to 10 seconds or less), lowest common denominator programming, credulous presentations on pseudoscience and superstition, but especially a kind of celebration of ignorance. As I write, the number-one videocassette rental in America is the movie *Dumb and Dumber*. ‘Beavis and Butthead’ remain popular (and influential) with young TV viewers. The plain lesson is that study and learning – not just of science, but of anything – are avoidable, even undesirable.

We’ve arranged a global civilization in which most crucial elements – transportation, communications, and all other industries; agriculture, medicine, education, entertainment, protecting the environment; and even the key democratic institution of voting – profoundly depend on science and technology. We have also arranged things so that almost no one understands science and technology. This is a prescription for disaster. We might get away with it for a while, but sooner or later this combustible mixture of ignorance and power is going to blow up in our faces.

Avoidable human misery is more often caused not so much by stupidity as by ignorance, particularly our ignorance about ourselves. I worry that, especially as the Millennium edges nearer, pseudoscience and superstition will seem year by year more tempting, the siren song of unreason more sonorous and attractive.

Where have we heard it before? Whenever our ethnic or national prejudices are aroused, in times of scarcity, during challenges to national self-esteem or nerve, when we agonize about our diminished cosmic place and purpose, or when fanaticism is bubbling up around us – then, habits of thought familiar from ages past reach for the controls.

The candle flame gutters. Its little pool of light trembles. Darkness gathers. The demons begin to stir.”

— Carl Sagan (1934-1996), American Astronomer,
Planetary Scientist, Science Communicator, *The
Demon-Haunted World: Science as a Candle in the Dark*, 1995.

Topic II

“To the givers of this beautiful reward, my thanks, from the heart. My family, my agents, my editors, know that my being here is their doing as well as my own, and that the beautiful reward is theirs as much as mine. And I rejoice in accepting it for, and sharing it with, all the writers who’ve been excluded from literature for so long – my fellow authors of fantasy and science fiction, writers of the imagination, who for fifty years have watched the beautiful rewards go to the so-called realists.

Hard times are coming, when we’ll be wanting the voices of writers who can see alternatives to how we live now, can see through our fear-stricken society and its obsessive technologies to other ways of being, and even imagine real grounds for hope. We’ll need writers who can remember freedom – poets, visionaries – realists of a larger reality.

Right now, we need writers who know the difference between production of a market commodity and the practice of an art. Developing written material to suit sales strategies in order to maximize corporate profit and advertising revenue is not the same thing as responsible book publishing or authorship.

Yet I see sales departments given control over editorial. I see my own publishers, in a silly panic of ignorance and greed, charging public libraries for an e-book 6 or 7 times more than they charge customers. We just saw a profiteer try to punish a publisher for disobedience, and writers threatened by corporate fatwa.* And I see a lot of us, the producers, who write the books and make the books accepting this – letting commodity profiteers sell us like deodorant, and tell us what to publish, what to write.

Books aren’t just commodities; the profit motive is often in conflict with the aims of art. We live in capitalism, its power seems inescapable – but then, so did the divine right of kings. Any human power can be resisted and changed by human beings. Resistance and change often begin in art. Very often in our art, the art of words.

I’ve had a long career as a writer, and a good one, in good company. Here at the end of it, I don’t want to watch American literature get sold down the river. We who live by writing and publishing want and should demand our fair share of the proceeds; but the name of our beautiful reward isn’t profit. Its name is freedom.”

— Ursula K. Le Guin (1929-2018), American Author,
Acceptance Speech for the National Book Foundation
Medal for Distinguished Contribution to American
Letters, November 19, 2014.

*fatwa – a legal ruling on a point of Islamic law given by
a qualified Islamic jurist in response to a question
posed by a private individual, judge, or government

READY WRITING STATE WINNERS 2025

1A

The Modern Day Plague: Ignorance

Though one may think that in the current digitalized age of 2025 that the human race itself is the most intelligent that it has ever been, that theory couldn't be further from the truth. In the era of abundant knowledge and technology that we so happily live in, it may seem reasonable to entertain the idea that humans have got it figured out and to suggest that as our technologies increase in complexity, so do we. However, is the average person actually becoming a more intelligent and dependable creature or are they themselves becoming so dependent on technologies which they don't even understand, that without them they would be deemed effectively useless. With the increased dependence on the internet for information, on air conditioners for comfort, and cars for travel, the average person has no need to learn basic skills that 100 years ago would have been necessary for survival. Although our societies have advanced, we have not, but rather are willingly running down a path that leads to nothing more than one of the scariest concepts imaginable: ignorance.

American Astronomer Carl Sagan once wrote "The dumbing down of America is most evident in the slow-decay of substantive content in the enormously influential media" and continued by referencing "30-second sound bites" as an example. Now, not only is the average American faced with 30 second sound bites, but with more videos, social media posts, advertisements, songs, movies, and TV shows than one could ever imagine. Why would one ever need to go outside or talk with someone again if there is an almost infinite amount of dopamine releasing content that can be accessed by almost everybody with absolute ease? Well obviously, to some people there are an abundance of reasons to do so, but for many the internet is their life.

When people spend their life with their face in a phone, TV, or computer, how will they ever learn about how the world works or even how to talk with people. The book "The Anxious Generation" touches on this subject by suggesting that if one is not forced to live an actual life, how could they ever be capable of normal everyday things without extreme anxiety and difficulty. The vast knowledge and entertainment of the internet can be beneficial to someone who uses it properly, but can also be turned into a drug that turns people into ignorant and incapable zombies which depend on new technology which for thousands of years did not even exist.

Even though the internet may be a potent ingredient in the shortening of our attention spans and lack of understanding of our world, the complexity of other technologies is also responsible for the ignorance of many. If you ask the average American how does your TV, microwave, air conditioner, car, or phone work, odds are they will have no clue. Although some may have general ideas of how one part of some of these things may work, it's unlikely that they fully understand in its entirety. This is not to say that they are not intelligent for not knowing, but rather that the technologies that we use on a day to day basis are so complicated that it would even take a very intelligent person a long time to wrap their head around it. Many of the technologies that we use were made by a handful of super geniuses with an intelligence far outshining most everybody on the planet. It's impossible to explain to everybody how every piece of technology works, so it results in a large majority of people clueless at how something which they are dependent on even works.

In the 1800's there were many impressive technologies, however they were at least simple enough for almost everybody to comprehend. Attaching a horse to a carriage, weaving cotton to make clothes, and starting a fire using nothing but rocks are all primitive technologies

compared to today, but are all tasks that the modern person, much less the modern American would be able to replicate. This is not to say that the modern person is less capable than someone from that time, but instead so dependent on the advanced technology that we use today, that we don't even understand simple technologies of the past. Albert Einstein expresses this idea with one of his famous quotes which simplifies to although WW3 might be fought with weapons of great power and destruction, WW4 will be fought with sticks and stones. This idea reiterates the idea that if the technology of today gets destroyed, it will take decades if not centuries to rebuild all due to our lack of understanding of how our technologies function.

Ignorance is one of the many great tragedies that we face today and will continue to face in the future but that doesn't mean we are entirely hopeless. If one wishes to break the cycle of dependence and a lack of knowledge, then there are many ways to do so. One can stop relying on technologies that they might have become accustomed to. One can put down their phone every once and a while to focus on creating a real life that's worth living. But most important of all, one can learn. In our age of information ignorance is a choice, if we truly wish to be set free from the shackles of not knowing then all we have to do is learn. Learn about cars. Learn about gardening. Learn about anything that interests you. Learning is the counter to ignorance and if everyone contributes then we might have a shot at bouncing back from WW3 or at the very least have a more intelligent society.

All in all, although we live in an age of information, we also live in an age of ignorance.

We have become so reliant on technologies to the point where if we lost them it would be cataclysmic. As society has advanced, but we have not. We have so much information at our fingertips yet we never seem to reach for it. But that doesn't have to be the case. If one wishes to redefine the norm of being ignorant, they have to put in the work by living a real life and

learning about the world. It may seem easy to go about life minding our own business while being tangled up in technologies that are (at least for the time being) beyond our understand, but if we wish to excel and to become intelligent knowledgeable members of society the we can pick up a book, open an article, or have a conversation and learn.

The Strategy of our Demon, and How to Fight Back

The only light remaining in the world glows weakly, providing a shallow, distorted view of our wretched condition. It urges itself to remain alit. Trembles. Quivers. Yet, one weak gust of wind kills the flame - our last hope is dead. The darkness consumes. Only now, in complete obscurity, is the assassin of our light visible. Only now is it clear that the demon of our ignorance has won.

Ignorance kills.

Indeed, the beginning of human existence marked the birth of a plaguing demon - a being that follows wherever we go, no matter how hard one tries to escape it. Its sole purpose is to blur the lines between what feels good and what's true, and to slowly nudge us back into superstition. Total darkness. Thus, we must fight against it.

How will it accomplish this goal, one may ask? It's simple: by promoting a world full of distractions from what's important- somewhere where knowledge is not only disregarded, but entirely forgotten. And when we reflect on our world today, it's clear that our demon has nearly succeeded. Because though reiterated time and time again, we live in a generation of distraction. The need for instant gratification, artificial intelligence, unhealthy fast food, and a constant attachment to a forever dinging, ringing and beeping iPhone diverts us from reality. It prohibits us from slowing down, from soaking in knowledge, and from taking the time to delve into the beauty of real, tangible, meaningful life. Of course, these distractions are the demon's latest strategies, and they're working. Therefore, we must fight against the urge to doom scroll social media for hours and give into the 30-second sound bites that kill our attention spans and

celebrate our ignorance. we must fight against the •simplification and, thus, stupidity of our society, even when it surrounds us. Even when the darkness is suffocating.

Nevertheless, this suffocation isn't a brand-new cultural phenomenon fueled by the rising reliance on ChatGPT. As American Astronomer Carl Sagan asks, "where have we heard it before?" To answer this, it dates back centuries, as does the demonic ignorance of humankind. Greek philosopher Plato commented on this ignorance innumerable times, even going as far as to oppose democracy itself. Though this idea seems completely distasteful to the American mind where democracy is presented as the savior of our country that stands as the unwavering best in the world, Plato's reasoning was solid: if people were not educated, and did not possess the desire to become educated, why should they be given the powerful ability to choose leaders? And though I don't detest our country's chosen system of government, this stance undoubtedly sheds light on the dimmed intelligence of citizens ages ago, which eerily resembles that of today and proves the stagnancy of our familiarity with ignorance. Furthermore, though, Plato believed that society would never be righted until philosophers became kings or vice versa, and his first idea for fulfillment provided an excellent route for this to be achieved; put simply, "think more." Though straightforward, these words offer a proficient plan for overcoming ignorance: for killing darkness, once and for all. Thus, adhering to Plato's beliefs - engaging in Socratic discussion, reflecting on the distractions eating society alive, and braving the path to knowledge may provide the path toward success, even if it's the most perilous journey of one's life.

To preface, it is. This difficulty is the reason people forever reside in the shallow end of life. They're too afraid to take the leap into the great wide sea and, because of this, will always remain ignorant of its glorious beauty. They'll never gain new outlook or perspective, and they'll never have the knowledge that is so wonderful—and terrifying—to possess.

Because as we've so often been reminded, knowledge is power. Though cliché, this simple statement encompasses the double-edged sword that is knowing. On one hand, obtaining powerful knowledge is obtaining the skills to fend off darkness - to keep the light alive. However, with power comes hardship, evil, and suffering. Thus, it takes strength to put aside selfish bliss and move into the realm of ability to fight the darkness. In the autobiography *Learning to Read and Write*, Frederick Douglass expresses this unfortunate dilemma, asserting that he "envied his fellow slaves for their stupidity." In fact, he even classifies his gained knowledge as a curse rather than a blessing, as he "gained the knowledge of his wretched condition without the remedy." He was forced to observe his chains with a new perspective that illuminated society's unforgivable faults. He could no longer live simply because he was called to the front lines of this ancient battle. However, he fails to acknowledge that through overcoming his ignorance - and despite personal hardship - he was able to make a profound impact on the world. He not only protected the light, but kindled it into a flame that remains burning in the hearts of millions, even today. He was selfless in his mission toward knowledge, and if we wish to prevent the extinguishing of his flame, we must be selfless, too.

So, we must take a leap of faith into danger, and into the battle. We must push aside our inherent desire for selfish ignorance and the peace that comes with it to delve into knowledge, even when the facts are painful to carry. In doing so, the demon of ignorance cannot win, no matter how hard it tries. Because as long as knowledge is alive, light is alive. And although this light provides us with the view of our condition, it also provides the view of our prosperity. It illuminates our humanness - the good, the bad, and the ugly, but never the forgotten. Never the victims to a suffocating, distorting demon. Never erased by darkness.

Exponential Decay

It's easy to get lost in the moment, and revel in the remarkable achievements happening each and every day here, in the land of the free. Diseases are cured, new tech is built up from the ground, and, slowly but surely, people learn to accept one another. However, in hindsight, America is on a hill- a slight decline that's practically invisible as we slowly roll down. As we gain and gain, it distracts us from the insurmountable number of losses we suffer. Countless Americans lose their autonomy piece by piece to those whom they blindly offer their loyalty. Technology leaves people of all ages clueless in its absence. We have reached a summit where a need for information no longer precedes action. Instead we jump rashly, and blindly trust in systems around us to create a pillow-soft landing. Before we even know what's happening, ignorance and susceptibility will lead the eventual demise of our country.

American spiritual leader Ram Dass is famous for once saying, "Eat it like it is". This quote was in reference to a laid-back mindset, and the thought that the world should simply be accepted as-is to promote a peaceful existence. However, it's philosophies like these that contribute to the downfall of society. Simply "eating it like it is" infers that people don't have the ability to create change or tear themselves from a harmful cycle. A stoic acceptance of the way things are is a welcome mat for more negative change. This ideal is paralleled in philosopher Plato's allegory of the cave. This allegory compares society to a small group of people inside a cave. There is fire within the cave, and the people pass their time admiring the flickering flames and creating puppets with shadows. This casting of light is all the people are familiar with, so they spend each day enjoying and accepting it as all there is to life. It could be said that these cave dwellers constantly "eat it like it is". The difference between these two situations is that

Plato's allegory includes the thought of escape. Once one escapes the cave, others follow, and soon learn that there's more to be seen than shadows on a wall. Ideals like Dasein's trap society within Plato's cave. A peaceful state of mind can be achieved without turning a blind eye to opportunities for change. It may have been difficult for Plato's cave dwellers to take in a new world beyond their comfortable shadows, but they broke free from their projected life and began a journey of discovery. Harmless pebbles like a lifestyle quote can create deep craters in the face of human spirit and tilt the tables, worsening America's already slippery slope. It's important to fight ignorance, and not allow it to slink into everyday life through something so casual.

The novel *Things Fall Apart* by Chinua Achebe details an African civilization that is slowly torn down by white men. The story begins with an explanation of the way of life in a vibrant African community, and details different roles and responsibilities of citizens. The author takes you on a journey through their peaceful and collaborative system while introducing families and important characters. The story ends with the protagonist committing suicide via hanging. What happened between the beginning and end was the work of the snapping jaws of susceptibility. The white men came peacefully at first, but slowly overtook everything the Africans had ever known. Unaware of the covert plundering occurring under their noses, the African people lost their homes, families, religion, practices, and their spirit was undeniably broken. While their story wasn't one of ignorance, it was one of susceptibility. They had no idea such a vengeful group could have reached them, and they were left unequally matched to the white men's forces. Achebe's novel goes to show the dangers of vulnerability, and how quickly a society can fall. The society he spoke of had no idea of impending change. We live with the gift of awareness, and must not let ourselves fall susceptible.

The short story *Harrison Bergeron* by Kurt Vonnegut Jr. details a dystopian world where all people are forced to live in equality. While this may sound ideal, it was taken to an extreme that made it intolerable for citizens. The people lived under a woman known as the Handicapper General, and she instated handicaps for anyone considered "above average". These included hideous masks for those with beauty, wrist and ankle weights for those with strength, and, worst of all, mental handicaps for those of great intelligence. One mental handicap used on a primary character was an in-ear device that sent out piercing shrieks, distracting the user and preventing the formation of any daring or revolutionary thought. The people are so blinded that when a brave young man loses his life attempting to stand up to the Handicapper General, they forget him within the hour. All of this hurt was made possible through ignorance and susceptibility. The people were so easily manipulated that they allowed themselves to slowly be dragged into a system that banned individuality and stripped away talent. While this short story goes to extremes, it's not difficult to believe that modern society could head down the path of something similarly intense. It may not deal with equality specifically, but if people continue to be so easily manipulated, who knows what situation humanity could end up in. Turning a blind eye on negative situations makes a person vulnerable, leading to eventual pain. If America does not take leaps and bounds against ignorance and susceptibility, the world of *Harrison Bergeron* could seem less dystopian day by day.

Ignorance and ease with which people are manipulated is only increased by modern commodities like social media and artificial intelligence. Day by day people lose their ability to think for themselves. Social media platforms like TikTok, Instagram, and recently Facebook provide users with short videos, typically around thirty seconds, to scroll through quickly. This dramatically shortens a user's attention span and leaves them with a need for constant

stimulation. This may not seem impactful, but these platforms slowly eat away at viewers' ability to absorb information. The apps are also majorly targeted toward young people, meaning their shortened attention spans are destroying time in the classroom. Many students are unable to finish assignments, readings, and lectures without feeling bored or antsy, meaning that they do not learn material to the fullest extent. The doctors of tomorrow can't listen to lab instructions provided to them in class today. Future teachers have never listened to a full lecture. These apps that we see as incredible technological reveals are eating us from the inside out. Artificial intelligence provides an incredible negative contribution as well. Hundreds of jobs become obsolete as they are overtaken by AI, and, again, children are impacted in the classroom. Assignments can easily be plugged in and completed by programs like ChatGPT or Grammarly Generative AI. The popular texting app Snapchat even comes with a built in AI assistant that can receive photos of homework and provide solutions. These forms of technology contribute to ignorance by removing society's ability to think for themselves. Meanwhile, helpful and educational technology slowly fades away. The PBS network, for example, is currently being defunded. Thousands of hours of child psychology go into the formation of PBS programs in order to ensure that children consume material that will developmentally assist them. PBS is also free, meaning children of low-income families have access to these helpful programs and games. It speaks volumes that harmful technological innovations receive praise and promotion while helpful ones are torn down. This shows the advance of ignorance, and its long fingers wrap around us with every scroll on TikTok, or essay by ChatGPT. Protecting things that protect our abilities to think independently is the best step away from demise.

Modern times are incredible to live in, as we experience new things each and every day. However, we must make ourselves painfully aware of everything happening in our surroundings.

Becoming ignorant and susceptible will cause harm that may be irreversible, but there is still hope. Waking up each day and choosing to be aware, choosing to educate, choosing to pay attention is what this country needs to prevent our constant exponential decay from worsening. If we allow ourselves to be blinded by the things around us, ignorance and susceptibility will lead to our demise.

The Inclination to Reason

While perusing the internet or sauntering down a city street or walking through the halls of a high school, the more thoughtful of life's number are sensitive to a certain aspect of their surroundings: that something that once resided in days past is all but absent. It is as though somewhere between the present and America's past a prodigious chasm had opened and swallowed the thing—the defining and vital thing—that permeated the air of the country's past. Upon further inspection of the modern era's pollution it calls entertainment and news, that which is missing can now be identified by the more advanced and aware members of society: the ubiquity of intellect and reason. It is not difficult to see the alarming fact that the United States of America is in a stark intellectual decline; gone are the days in which the pursuit of the more erudite and cultured arts are unanimously encouraged, and its brutal effects are obvious. The modern American is a mindless drone that meanders through existence without a thought of something greater than what form of entertainment he may pollute his brain with next.

Yet, though this decline is painfully obvious, its gravity is not understood. The only reason why a writer or artist of the same respect and magnitude as someone like Mark Twain or Vincent van Gogh has yet to emerge is because the grimness of intellectual lack has yet to unanimously set in. And such gravity can only be understood when one realizes that it is in human nature to reason and be knowledgeable; success, happiness, and innovation are all rooted in the innate human ability to think. The want of such reason and intellect can and will only ever lead to the ruination of both a person and the society in which he lives—one needs only to look at the state of modern America to see that fact.

As implied prior, to go against intellect and reason would be to go against a fundamental principle of human nature, but what truly qualifies the ability to think deeply as a person's natural inclination? Such was answered and reasoned by the great Greek thinker Aristotle in his work *Nicomachean Ethics*. Aristotle used the analogy of the Greek word "techne," or essentially one's ability in their craft or job. He postulated that something identity is determined by their techne—essentially what it is the best at doing. For example, a lawn mower is defined as such because it is phenomenal at trimming blades of grass, and its ability to do so is unmatched by any other; the same can be applied to man. Humans are amazing at a lot of things; they are the apex predators of the world, but they can be outhunted by many members of the animal kingdom. The one thing—the one trait—humans are consistently the champion of is the ability for deep and revolutionary thought. There is no animal, no matter how intelligent, that could devise such ideas as religion or philosophy or science. Thus, by their nature, humans are defined by their ability of thought since they are truly the finest at it—though in some cases this is hard to believe. Human techne is that of reason; it is one's true nature to allow oneself to think deeply, but to neglect that ability would be to deny one's nature.

With such an idea in mind, it must now be qualified whether or not this aspect of human nature is right to be followed, after all, using Aristotle's principles, self-preservation and deceit can easily be classified as human techne as well. To answer this, two situations will be presented: one in which the nature of reason is embraced and one in which it is not.

Beginning with the former, very few can compare to the success and erudite nature of American polymath Benjamin Franklin. Needing little introduction, Franklin can justly be referred to as one of the most influential men in the nation's history; to this extent, he personally reported in his autobiography that the scale and enormity of his success can be attributed to his learning to read,

write, and think. Franklin was not born into a learned household; his parents could barely afford to send him to grammar school, and all the books he owned were second-hand or purchased with what little money Franklin could save. In spite of this, he did everything in his power to pursue his academic prowess; he read and wrote at every possible opportunity from his days in boyhood until his eventual death. It was this ability to write that awarded him meetings with governors and statesmen and kings. This incredible depth of thought is what set him apart from the common people of the 18th century; intellect is an inherently virtuous trait. Franklin followed his nature to think and deeply reason—to enlighten his mind in the face of a world that did not encourage such a pursuit. And, as peculiar as it is, there exist prominent parallels between the attitudes of Franklin's day and the present in regard to being intellectual. Only now, pursuing knowledge in the face of such is not so much a matter of availability but instead a matter of initiative—initiative to pursue the virtuous benefit of strengthening one's intellectual prowess.

Now that the former of the previously proposed situations has been presented, the latter of such must follow, still supporting the argument made in the analysis of Franklin's life. The rejection of life's nature to reason cannot be better illustrated than through the presentation of the dystopian world of Ray Bradbury's *Fahrenheit 451*. In the novel, Bradbury introduces an America in which all books have been banned, and all media is controlled by an authoritarian government. Within this world, every part of the country is devoid of revolutionary thought; there is no intellectual conversation to be had or interesting article to be read. The story follows the fireman Guy Montag, a man tasked with burning any books that remains in existence, and his doubts about the validity of the laws of his country. His wife Mildred, the subject of this example, serves as Montag's antithesis in that she has become entirely subservient to their government. She does not question the nature of books; she cares only about when her “family,”

a soap opera, will appear on their parlor wall television. She truly cares little for Montag and what he has to say about their government, but she is thoroughly enthralled by the events of her life. She has become so brainwashed by her government that she can no longer see the absurdity of caring about a televised family more than her husband. Mildred's character is meant to be an extreme, yet she seems to resemble someone one would meet walking down the street. When the presence of intellectual thought has been swallowed by an abyss—an absence, people become these mindless drones—just as many are today. The world is filled with thousands of Mildreds, wandering the world, only caring about what they could watch next. Such is the case when one defies the natural inclination of reason—the ruination of mind, body, and home.

The statement that the natural human desire for intellect, reason, and knowledge should in every case be followed and acted upon can now be adequately qualified. As demonstrated through Bradbury's Mildred, the absence of this complex thought results in a drone of a person—an utter robot without the ability to think for oneself. An empty mind is constantly searching to pollute itself with foul entertainment; such can be called the state of the modern world. Compare this reality to that of Franklin's life; there existed in his time a similar chasm to what lurks in America now—a sinkhole that resulted in the loss of the ubiquity of complex thought and reason—and Franklin elected to mend it and profit from the virtue of intelligence. Though the morality of much of what can be classified as human nature is questioned heavily—rightfully so—it can be understood that this inclination to reason is a nature that all should be encouraged to follow to the best of one's ability.

To a degree, all people can see the intellectual sinkhole modern America is falling into; it is simply a matter of whether one cares or whether one possesses the knowledge and foresight to care. Understanding that it has always been the nature of man to reason and think intellectually is

integral to mending that sinkhole—the absence one feels upon observing the public. It will always be more desirable than not to be knowledgeable purely because it is in one's nature. And failure to adhere to that natural feeling—that natural desire—to pursue a great mind will lead to the country's ruin. Bradbury's world is dangerously close to reality, one can only hope that people will soon realize that. Unfortunately, it is more likely than not that no one has ever even read the book.

Where Angels Fear to Tread

Rugged individualism lies at the heart of the American national mythology, but so too does the lilting lyric of our native troubadours, the beguiling brushstrokes of our homegrown artists, the mellifluous melodies of our folk singers. Many artifacts of our national heritage serve as paeans to liberty, from Emma Lazarus's famous tribute to "huddled masses yearning to breathe free" to Beyonce's anthemic cry, "Freedom, freedom, I can't move." We venerate the cowboys, the astronauts, the titans of industry, in vibrant tapestries of sound and color. Yet in the Information Age, American literature is at a crossroads caught between the jaws of profit and prophecy, we often choose the former stubbornly insisting that the American Dream is a vision of luxury rather than soulful, authentic expression. Scandals like Cambridge Analytica and Ancestry.com's data leakages do not just represent an invasion of privacy. AI generation programs such as Chat GPT and Dall-E do not just represent an onslaught on our artistic imagination as a people. Rather, these events symbolize a more profound truth about the integrity of our nation: the arts are our final defense against the destruction of democracy.

In the annals of history, art has always been utilized to stabilize or destabilize tyranny. In Ancient China, the first emperor of the Qin dynasty staged a mass book burning due to the threat artists and intellectuals posed to his legitimacy. In Nazi Germany, Adolf Hitler commissioned propaganda films, such as those of Leni Riefenstahl, who glorified the Third Reich by utilizing the cinematic technique of priming- using epic, orchestral music and slow-panning shots to confer majesty onto the totalitarian regime. In the 1970s, the Sex Pistols released a parody of "God Save the Queen" in protest against Britain's emergent conservatism, which would ultimately culminate in the rise of Thatcherism and chronic underfunding for social welfare

programs, such as the National Health Service. In 21st century America, Silicon Valley presents a high-on-insurmountable challenge to contemporary scholars and creatives: how do you keep your head above AI generated water? Corporate monopolies like NVIDIA dominate tech markets, stifling the natural competition that is the lifeblood of the American economy. The stockpiling of consumer data by companies such as Meta and ByteDance means that American citizens are not fully knowledgeable about how that data is used. Companies like MyHeritage and Ancestry have been heavily criticized by American media for their biodata leaks. Ancestry in particular faced widespread backlash from its consumer base when hackers accessed Chinese and Ashkenazi Jewish biodata in 2019. Since then, many consumers have veered away from uploading their genetic information to these platforms, fearing the ramifications of insurance companies potentially purchasing this data or other nefarious outcomes. The culture of fear Silicon Valley has established around the use of technology inhibits the potential benefits artists could experience by making full use of it. Platforms such as Tumblr, Goodreads, and DeviantArt can serve as breeding grounds for creative expression, and communities of artists often congregate on these platforms to exchange ideas and innovate new styles of art like vaporwave. However, these platforms have a seedy underbelly. Tumblr has faced controversy due to its former advertisement of pornographic websites, particularly since Tumblr's demographics are primarily teenagers and young adults. Goodreads is owned by billionaire Jeff Bezos, who has been widely lambasted by the American public for the low wages and poor working conditions of his Amazon workers. DeviantArt's consolidation of a myriad of artistic works has also resulted in the systematic theft of these works by AI generation services, denying artists around the world the right to their intellectual property. This poses limitless dangers to democratic ideals.

In the 21st century, Americans have witnessed an uptick of fascism in our own backyard, as well as in the world more broadly. The surge in nationalistic, racist, and xenophobic rhetoric from leaders like Donald Trump in the US, Viktor Orban in Hungary, and Pierre Poilievre in Canada coincides with a steep decline in artistic expression. Correlation is not causation however so let us identify the cause: the tech boom of the 2010s. Websites like X (formerly Twitter), TikTok, and Instagram made mass communication infinitely more accessible than in previous eras. and this essentially constitutes Pandora's Box for artists and writers. Wading through the depths of sociopolitical discourse on X distracts from finishing one's first novel, and the climate of "BookTok" the literary side of TikTok, is so hostile to intellectual pluralism that a rising tide of young authors accuse romantasy authors of catering to conservatism in their works. Some of these criticisms are legitimate—Sarah J. Maas, author of the New York Times bestselling series *A Court of Thorns and Roses*, and Cassandra Clare, author of the *Underworld* series, both heavily feature heteronormative storylines in their works. But just because an author depicts heteronormativity does not mean they despise LGBTQ+ individuals It should not be the prerogative of cisgender, heterosexual authors to represent lived experiences they have neither lived, nor experienced. Likewise, just because many of an author's works feature individuals of European descent does not mean that these works are inherently racist or Eurocentric. Maas has also been criticized for her failure to include characters of color in her works, which also generally draw upon Western European and Ashkenazi Jewish cultures. Yet arguably more damaging is the misrepresentation of minority groups by white authors, such as *Twilight* author Stephenie Meyer's depiction of the Quileute people in her works. The Quileute are a real indigenous group with real folktales and a real history of oppression in the form of Indian residential schools. Meyer's choice to negate that history and replace it with her Quileute

characters having werewolf lineages, without the informed consent of the Quileute people, is far more insidious than Maas following the adage "write what you know". However, Maas and Meyer share a conundrum. Their choice whether to depict or not depict marginalized peoples in their works is a Catch-22: if they represent marginalized groups, they risk misrepresentation, but if they don't represent marginalized groups, they risk erasure. Cries of "no true feminist" would rain down in true fallacious fashion. Thus, Internet literary discourse ironically contributes to the phenomenon it hopes to quash: the repression of intellectual pluralism.

Despite the Herculean labor maintaining authenticity in the digital age requires, Americans crave authenticity more than ever. Crowds of adoring fans laud figures like Sabrina Carpenter and Taylor Swift for the perceived relatability of their lyrics, while castigating figures who represent unattainable ideals, such as Sydney Sweeney, who Elle and Vogue have both described as Gen-Z's take on the blonde bombshell trope. When Swift sings "who could ever leave me darling/but who could stay" and uses the metaphor of an archer for her self-sabotaging tendencies, we cheer, but when Sweeney's character Cassie Howard on the TV show Euphoria admits to feeling insecure about her appearance, her character's younger sister tells her to "shut up". Swift and Sweeney are both successful artists, forged in an Eurocentric image of Americana that pop culture continues to perpetuate: blonde, pale, and slender. But only one is afforded the freedom to embrace her vulnerability in the public eye: Swift. In 2022, writer Tressie McMillan Cottom composed an article for the New York Times on the politics of blondness with a memorable line: "what could be so significant about a genetic trait, long after the expression of this trait has ceased to exist?" Natural blondness is common in individuals of European descent as children, but as melanin production increases in adulthood, gradually reduces in frequency. Artists like Sweeney and Swift do share objectification and oversexualization by the media and

by our patriarchal society—in 2017, Swift won a lawsuit against a music producer who sexually harassed her, receiving the symbolic damages of one dollar. The objectification and simultaneous demand for authenticity in American society points to a continuity in the artistic landscape of the digital age from previous eras: identity trumps artistic expression. Today, Leonardo Da Vinci's works are not just revered because of their own artistic merit, but because of Da Vinci's reputation as a polymath. If you took a random sample of Americans, you'd be hard pressed to find an American who can name one of his works beyond the Mona Lisa. Reputation is consequential: it informs the way we as human beings relate to art and imbue it with meaning. But reputation and authenticity are also highly consequential in the world of politics—they inform the way human beings vote, which informs how art is protected in our society.

Even amid the carnage of the digital age, I have faith in the next generation of artists to overcome these challenges. I have faith in those who would step beyond the bliss of ignorance to speak truth to power. Where once absolutism was the rule of law in Europe, ardently defended by philosophers like Thomas Hobbes, who credited absolutism as a favorable alternative to the state of nature in his treatise *Leviathan*, it no longer is. Hobbes did not represent the masses of artists who clamored against absolutist rule. In fact, Enlightenment philosopher John Locke's assertion that the people are entitled to rebel against their government in order to protect their natural rights was later employed as a core tenet of the U.S. Constitution, reflected in its commitment to “life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness.” When socialist realism dominated the USSR, novelists like Mikhail Bulgakov satirized it and flouted its conventions, with novels like the *Master and Margarita*. When the Jazz Age normalized greed and laissez-faire capitalism, Sinclair Lewis wrote *Babbitt* in response, to reaffirm the transcendent beauty of community and issue a jeremiad against the commodification of the American psyche. As long as philosophers dream up

ideas that outlast mortal men, our humanity will persevere. As long as teachers instill the value of independent thought, our humanity will persevere. As long as artists venture where angels fear to tread, our humanity will persevere.

The Cost of Creativity

Ever since the dawn of time, humans have needed things such as air, water and food to survive. While all of those things remain necessities, they have all essentially been boiled down into one thing: money. Money has a habit of looming ominously over nearly every action taken in our lives, whether it be buying food, driving our cars or creating art. As the cost of living ever increases, people tend to choose stable industries as their life paths. Even in an industry as relatively risky as the art one, whether it be in a subset of painting, sculpting, singing, writing or more, people now opt to forsake genuine boldness and innovation for a chance at dominating the capitalist game.

This change in production of art can be traced back to the days of Ancient Greece. At that point in the progression of human history, Greek artists had dedicated themselves to striving for nothing less than perfection. Near the earlier days of their artistry, the Greeks represented the human body through works such as the Anavysos Kouros and Peplos Kore. These works, while impressive at the time, were indubitably missing something human about them; whether it was their rigid stance or archaic smile, people could very easily recognize that something was off. Eventually, there came the status of Doryphoros, a glorious piece of marble carved perfectly to represent precise human proportions. This artwork set the standard for years of artists looking to represent the human body because they saw the artwork as something incredible, and it was. At that time, the Greeks were not looking for extraordinary profit or fame, but to improve themselves and their work to a place where they were worthy enough to recreate G-d's greatest creation: man. By the 20th century, however, this desire to help humanity reach something spectacular had diminished. Works such as those of Andy Warhol, for example, were all about

mass production. Some of his pieces, such as Marilyn Triptych or his illustrious and venerated soup cans, were reproduced en masse until he was known worldwide, and his obsessions were not with perfection, nor product, but on celebrity. This capitalistic drive leaves his work devoid of soul, much unlike the works of many artists that came before him.

The more modern the Earth has become, the more art has shifted to a different form: television, an outstanding blend of writing, acting, music, clothes and design. Even though it is now in a different form, the pattern of trading passion and meaning for money is still obnoxiously present. For example, the renowned sitcom “It’s Always Sunny in Philadelphia” is about to embark on its seventeenth season. At the beginning of the show’s iconic run, the series was centered around tackling different social issues in an absurdly comedic way. In its first season alone, the show dealt with topics such as racism, abortion and molestation, making sure to provide grave admonitions surrounding each one. However, the more recent the seasons become, some of the show’s brilliance dims as the plot lines center less around evoking social change and more around keeping the show afloat for as long as its creators can profit from it. Although the show is a prime example of valuing longevity over greatness, it is most definitely not the only piece of media created that does so. In regards to movies, the Marvel Cinematic Universe is liable for doing the very same thing.

Marvel was a company that once dominated the film industry, producing superhero films galore. However, after the release of their 2019 film “Avengers: Endgame,” the company was experiencing a financial high. Naturally, they wanted to keep their success, and they chose to do so by distributing movies and television series at a rate previously unseen from them. Due to this, the quality of each of their products took a serious hit, and the oversaturation of the company’s

repeated capitalist efforts left fans with a bitter taste in their mouths. Nowadays, one of their films is considered successful just for not being a dramatic let down.

At the end of the day, that perfectly exemplifies the issue with the art industry marketing its products to strictly the purpose of consumption—it leads to art losing its meaning. Singers used to write of politics and peace, whereas now they sing of aesthetics and attractiveness. Authors used to explore one's purpose and existential meaning, whereas now they write mindless, mass-produced murder mysteries. When audiences are no longer able to extract something deeper from the art presented to them, they tend to get bored. This boredom causes them to disengage from the art, leaving the artist without any consumers, and thereby money, which in turn forces them to sloppily throw something new together that they hope will catch an audience's attention. Unbeknownst to them, they are simply restarting the age-old cycle.